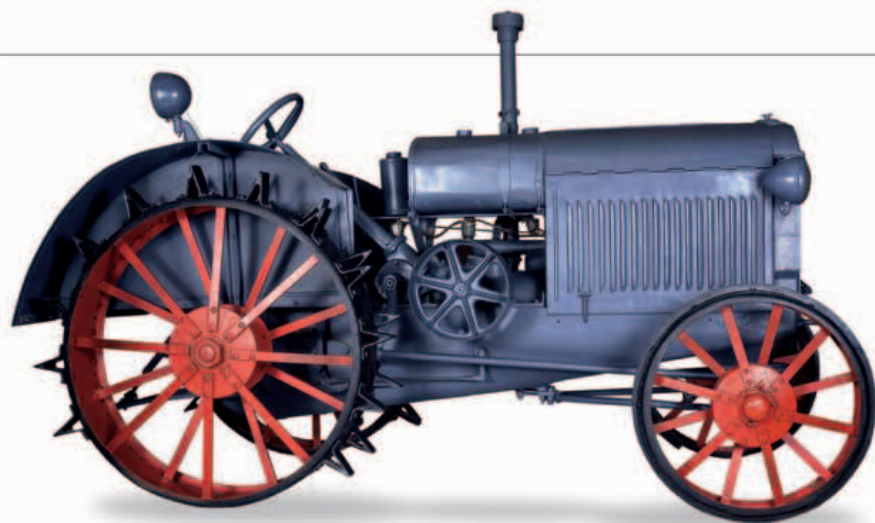




disastrous, producing reduced grain yields, violence, and famine. But over time, agriculture adjusted and living standards slowly began to rise.

Soviet farm tractor

In the 1930s, the first Soviet tractors were produced. They were kept at district stations and could only be used with party permission, thus keeping the farms under tight political control.

The “Great Terror”

Such rapid growth and change came at a price. Throughout his rule, while Stalin cultivated a propaganda image of himself as father of his people—benign, even godlike—the Soviet people suffered appalling hardships. Living standards were often subhuman, work was compulsory, and absenteeism a crime. Criticism of the communist system could lead to a sentence in those same forced labor camps created

by the Czars to crush dissent (see left).

A network of new prison camps was erected west of Moscow to house the thousands who fell foul of Stalin’s demands. The period 1936 to 1938, known as the “Great Terror,” saw the secret police launching witch-hunts against the party elite and the army. Political opponents were forced to confess to plotting against Stalin and summarily executed. In two years, some 690,000

people were executed and many thousands more imprisoned or exiled.

Symbol of socialism

These figures raise the hammer, symbol of the industrial worker, and the sickle, symbol of the peasantry. “Socialist Realism” was the only art style permitted under Stalin.

MARXIST REVOLUTIONARY 1879–1940

LEON TROTSKY

Leon Trotsky was a key figure in the Russian Revolution, a brilliant Marxist theorist, and a believer in international “permanent revolution.” In the early days of the Soviet Union he served as the People’s Commissar for Foreign Affairs and created the Red Army. After a power struggle with Stalin, he was expelled from the Soviet Union in 1929. Sentenced to death in his absence by a Moscow court—allegedly for plotting Stalin’s death—Trotsky found asylum in Mexico. In 1940 a Stalinist agent, who had befriended Trotsky, assassinated him by driving an ice pick into his skull.



The Soviet Bloc

The German invasion of the Soviet Union in 1941 caught Stalin by surprise, but after a bitterly fought war, his nation was ultimately victorious. At the 1945 conferences of Yalta and Potsdam, intended to secure lasting peace in the postwar world, Stalin secured the territories of eastern Poland and the Baltic States for Russia. New communist regimes emerged in Bulgaria, Romania, Hungary, Czechoslovakia, and East Germany. These became known as the Soviet Eastern Bloc, and were organized under Moscow’s control, replicating Soviet policies and institutions. The Soviet Union had become the only world power to rival the United States. Relationships with its western allies quickly soured after the war. Russia and the Eastern Bloc became engaged in what would be termed the Cold War with the capitalist West (see pp.406–07).

AFTER

Despite the hardships that the Soviet people had suffered during Stalin’s rule, there was genuine grief on his death in 1953. However, his legacy was a difficult one for the leadership of the Soviet Union.

DEATH OF STALIN

Stalin died in **mysterious circumstances** after eating dinner with close political colleagues, including **Lavrenty Beria**, former head of his secret police, and Stalin’s successor Nikita Khrushchev. It has been suggested that he had swallowed warfarin, a type of rat poison. His body was embalmed, and displayed in the Lenin Mausoleum in Red Square. After Stalin’s crimes were exposed, his **remains were removed** in 1961, and reburied in the Kremlin wall.

DE-STALINIZATION

Khrushchev swiftly began a process known as **De-Stalinization**, introducing basic legal rights, **allowing writers and artists greater freedoms**, and releasing huge numbers of political prisoners. Khrushchev also **encouraged foreign visitors** to the Soviet Union, but travel abroad for citizens remained strictly controlled. In 1956, Khrushchev denounced Stalin’s regime of “suspicion, fear, and terror” in a secret speech to the inner circle of the Communist Party and a report was issued to the public pointing to some of Stalin’s mistakes. The dominance of Stalinism finally began to



KHRUSHCHEV

diminish and a lesser cult of Lenin returned. That year, riots broke out in Poland, and the Hungarian people rebelled against Soviet rule. The **Hungarian uprising 448–49** was brutally repressed by the Soviet Red Army.



The official truth

Pravda, meaning “truth,” was the official newspaper of the Soviet Union between 1918 and 1991. Often used to parrot the views of the Communist Party, many regarded the paper as telling everything but the truth.

Ideal peasants

Without mechanized equipment, a Soviet women’s brigade uses crude rakes to gather up the hay harvest on a collective farm, in this 1941 photograph. Images such as this one tried to show that the peasants were happily carrying out Stalin’s severe agricultural policies; the reality was often very different.



Heroic images

This poster links Stalin with the revered Lenin, and typifies the heroic images Stalin used to promote himself.

